

JSS 2 ENGLISH STUDIES – FIRST TERM

TOPIC 1: SPEECH WORK / PHONETICS

1. Pure Vowels (Monophthongs)

Pure vowels are single vowel sounds. English has short and long pure vowels. Examples: /bɪ/ (bit), /i:/ (beat), /e/ (bed), /æ/ (cat), /ʊ/ (cup), /ɑ:/ (car), /ɒ/ (hot), /ɔ:/ (law), /ʊ/ (put), /u:/ (food), /ɜ:/ (bird), /ə/ (about – schwa).

Practise minimal pairs (e.g. ship/sheep, full/fool) to distinguish short and long vowels.

2. Consonant Sounds and Clusters

Consonants are produced with some obstruction of air. Important contrasts: /t/–/d/, /k/–/g/, /f/–/v/, /θ/–/ð/, /s/–/z/. Consonant clusters are groups of consonants (e.g. str- in street, -nts in wants). Practise clear pronunciation of clusters at the beginning and end of words.

3. Diphthongs

Diphthongs are gliding vowels (two sounds in one syllable). Common ones: /eɪ/ (day), /aɪ/ (my), /ɔɪ/ (boy), /ɪə/ (go), /aʊ/ (now), /ɪə/ (ear), /eə/ (air), /tʊə/ (tour).

4. Intonation, Stress and Rhythm

Intonation is the rise and fall of the voice. Rising intonation is common in yes/no questions; falling in statements and WH-questions. Word stress and sentence stress affect meaning and natural rhythm of English.

5. Summary

Good speech work improves listening, speaking and spelling. Practise pure vowels, consonants, clusters, diphthongs and basic intonation patterns regularly.

End of Topic 1